

Daily Gamecock *Opinion*

Requesting Statements

J.C. Vaught, Opinion Editor. Spring 2026

Purpose & Scope

This guide explains *when* to ask for an official statement, *how* to ask by email, and provides templates and examples for contacting universities, government agencies, companies, and other institutions. It is written for the Daily Gamecock *Opinion* section, but the practices apply broadly across student and professional journalism.

1 When You Must Seek a Statement

Seeking comment is both an ethical obligation and a practical legal safeguard. The “right of reply” is a core journalism principle.

Mandatory Situations

- **Criticism or allegations:** If an opinion piece criticizes a person or institution, you *must* ask them to respond before publication.
- **Potentially harmful assertions:** If your draft includes claims that could affect someone’s reputation (e.g., negligence, incompetence, discrimination), offer a fair chance to respond. This demonstrates lack of malice and reduces libel risk.
- **Policy or decision coverage:** When discussing university or government *actions*, seek on-the-record reasoning, timelines, or corrective steps from the relevant office.

Optional but Smart

If an opinion piece is primarily praise or personal reflection, comment is optional. However, if you cite new facts or statistics about an institution, confirm those details or offer a chance to clarify.

2 Who to Contact

Universities

Start with the *media relations/communications* office. Your editor should have a contact there. For USC, this is University Communications. Do not cold-email deans or department heads without going through official channels first.

Government Agencies

Identify the agency's press office or public information officer (PIO). For elected officials, contact the press secretary. If your facts hinge on records, consider filing a public-records request in parallel (FOIA at the federal level, SC Freedom of Information Act at the state level).

Companies & Nonprofits

Use the media relations email or the executive responsible for the policy at issue. Many organizations list a press inbox specifically for *requests for comment*. Check the "Press" or "Media" link in website footers.

3 How to Ask: Email Anatomy

Subject Line

Include your outlet, the topic, and a clear deadline. Concise subjects help sources triage quickly.

Good Subject Lines

Request for comment by 4 p.m. Friday -- USC housing waitlist
Media request (Daily Gamecock) -- Student fees oversight

Bad Subject Lines

Question
Hi
Need info ASAP

Opening & Context

- Identify yourself and the *Daily Gamecock*

- State the *opinion thesis* you are testing
- List *specific* questions tied to that thesis

Ground Rules on Attribution

Default is **on the record**. The Daily Gamecock does not accept “off the record” or “on background” sources without explicit approval from the managing editors. If a source requests background for safety or sensitivity, confirm the terms with your editor before agreeing.

Reasonable Time & Follow-up

Give institutions a fair window to respond relative to your publication schedule. Document all attempts to reach them. Only write “declined to comment” after bona fide efforts. If time is short, say so explicitly and offer phone availability for faster turnaround.

4 Email Templates

Template A: University

Use when seeking comment from USC or another university on policy, administration decisions, or campus issues.

Subject: Request for comment by [deadline] — [Topic]

Hello,

I'm [Name], an opinion writer with the *Daily Gamecock*. I'm writing about [thesis in one sentence].

To ensure fairness and accuracy, could I get a statement on the following?

1. What specific policies or constraints led to [issue] this semester?
2. What steps, if any, will USC take before [date] to address [concrete fix]?
3. How should affected students seek help in the meantime (office, link, timeline)?

My deadline is [date/time]. I can also be reached at [phone] if a call is easier.

Thank you,
Name

Daily Gamecock | [email] | [phone]

Template B: Government Agency

Use when seeking comment from city, state, or federal agencies on policy decisions, regulations, or enforcement actions.

Subject: Media request (Daily Gamecock) — [Agency] comment on [policy]

Hello [Press Officer/PIO],

I'm [Name], an opinion writer with the *Daily Gamecock*. I'm covering [policy/action] and its impact on [affected group].

For accuracy, please provide on-the-record responses to:

1. What is the agency's stated rationale and legal authority for [action]?
2. What data informed the decision? Please link to any public reports.
3. What recourse is available to affected students/residents?

My deadline is [date/time]. I'm available at [phone] for a call if that's more convenient.

Thank you,
Name

Daily Gamecock | [email] | [phone]

Template C: Company or Nonprofit

Use when seeking comment from businesses, landlords, vendors, or nonprofit organizations.

Subject: Request for comment — [Company] policy on [issue]

Hello,

I'm [Name], an opinion writer with the *Daily Gamecock*. In a forthcoming column about [issue], I'm asking [Company] to respond on the record to:

1. What is your current policy on [specific practice] as it applies to students?
2. Are there any planned changes, and what is the timeline?
3. How do you respond to concerns that [one-sentence critique]?

My deadline is [date/time]. I can be reached at [phone] if you'd prefer to speak by phone.

Thank you,
Name

Daily Gamecock | [email] | [phone]

5 Full Examples: Good vs. Needs Work

Good Email

Subject: Request for comment by 4 p.m. Friday — Counseling center wait times

Hello,

I'm Sarah Chen, an opinion writer with the *Daily Gamecock*. I'm writing a column arguing that the university's counseling center is critically understaffed, based on reports that students are waiting 3–4 weeks for initial appointments.

To ensure fairness, I'd like to include USC's perspective. Could you provide on-the-record responses to:

1. What is the current average wait time for an initial counseling appointment?
2. How many full-time counselors does the center currently employ, and how does this compare to the recommended ratio?
3. What steps, if any, is the university taking to reduce wait times before next semester?

My deadline is 4 p.m. Friday. I can also be reached at (803) 555-1234 if a phone call is easier.

Thank you,

Sarah Chen

Daily Gamecock | schen@email.sc.edu | (803) 555-1234

ANALYSIS: This email works because it clearly identifies the writer and outlet, states the thesis upfront (so the source knows exactly what claim they're responding to), asks specific and answerable questions, provides a deadline with enough lead time, and offers phone contact for faster response.

Needs Work

Subject: Question

Hi,

I'm writing an article about mental health stuff on campus and was wondering if you could give me any comment? I've heard students are having trouble getting appointments. Can you tell me anything about that?

Thanks,

Sarah

ANALYSIS: This email fails because the subject line is vague and easy to ignore, there's no deadline, the writer doesn't identify their outlet, the thesis is unclear ("mental health stuff"), the question is too open-ended ("tell me anything"), and there's no phone number or

full contact information.

6 Handling Responses

When They Respond

- **Thank them promptly** — Even a quick “Thank you, received” maintains the relationship.
- **Verify understanding** — If anything is unclear, ask a follow-up before publication rather than guessing.
- **Quote accurately** — Use their exact words. If you must paraphrase, ensure it’s fair.
- **Include relevant portions** — You don’t have to use everything, but don’t cherry-pick in a misleading way.
- **Save everything** — Keep the full email thread in case of disputes.

When They Don’t Respond

- **Follow up once** — Send a polite follow-up before your deadline (use Template D).
- **Try another channel** — If email fails, try phone. Document the attempt.
- **Note it fairly** — Write: “The university did not respond to a request for comment by publication time.” Do not say “refused to comment” unless they explicitly refused.
- **Don’t delay indefinitely** — If you’ve given reasonable time (typically 48–72 hours for non-urgent stories), you can proceed.

When They Push Back

- **“Off the record” requests** — Do not agree without editor approval. Say: “I’ll need to check with my editor on that.”
- **Requests to see the article** — You are not obligated to share your draft. You can offer to read back their quotes for accuracy.
- **Threats or intimidation** — Document everything and immediately inform your editor.
- **Spin or non-answers** — You can note that they “did not directly address” a question if their response dodges it.

7 Common Mistakes

Avoid These Pitfalls

- **Waiting until the last minute** — Sending a request two hours before deadline and then writing “declined to comment” is not good faith.
- **Asking leading questions** — “Why is USC so bad at handling housing?” puts them on the defensive. Ask neutral questions.
- **Burying the thesis** — If they don’t know what you’re arguing, they can’t respond meaningfully.
- **Forgetting your contact info** — Always include phone number. Many sources prefer to call.
- **Being rude or adversarial** — You want them to respond. Professional courtesy costs nothing.
- **Agreeing to “off the record” without understanding it** — This can kill your story. Always check with editors first.
- **Not documenting attempts** — If you can’t prove you tried to reach them, your editor can’t back you up.

8 Quick Checklist

Before You Send

1. **Is there criticism or an allegation?** If yes, you *must* seek comment.
2. **Have you stated your thesis clearly?** The source should know exactly what claim they're responding to.
3. **Are your questions specific and answerable?** Who, what, when, where, how — not vague asks.
4. **Did you include a deadline?** Be specific: date and time with timezone.
5. **Did you provide full contact info?** Name, outlet, email, and phone.
6. **Did you contact the right person/office?** Media relations first, not random employees.

After You Send

1. **Did you save a copy?** Screenshot or archive the sent email.
2. **Did you log the attempt?** Record who, when, and how you reached out.
3. **Did you follow up?** One follow-up before deadline if no response.
4. **Did you document non-response fairly?** “Did not respond” not “refused to comment.”